



theWindow

THE NEWSLETTER OF CHRIST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH, NEW HAVEN. VOLUME 1, ISSUE 2. SUMMER 1999.

The Spirit of Reformation Today!

BY PRESTON GRAHAM



from the Pastor

It's that time of year again, the annual "send off" of a college town ministry. It's always a time to reflect on the meaning of CPC and our peculiar calling in the grand scheme of God's redemptive work throughout the world. Take yesterday after church for example. Sitting out on the deck behind my house with the interns, there was a wonderful moment of reflection about the lessons learned throughout the year. Each intern shared how God had used you—the people of CPC—and your ministry to give them a vision for church planting and reformation. And there was sharing about the future—Toronto, Vancouver, Portland and New York City—places where our interns are being sent. And not surprisingly, three (if not four) will be involved in church planting efforts and are excited about it. All four are being sent out by God with *the spirit of reformation for today*. What do we mean by this?

Perhaps we should begin with what we *don't* mean. It seems that the language of "reformation" often implies polemics, narrow-mindedness or political "rightness" within ecclesiastical party-posturing. As I have toured the camps within our own denomination, I am often saddened that these things can obscure the true "spirit" of reformation. Reformation is often confused with reading Calvin or Luther and repeating either their language or their strategies for today. Too often it seems that "reformation" means doing what they did *again*, perhaps even using the same mediums to communicate what is otherwise a similar message. Reformation, in short, is often confused with being old fashioned or "traditional" with perhaps the added ingredient of edginess. I suppose it is not surprising that one of the more common accusations against Calvin in his day was that he was labeled a "progressive." Calvin

once complained, "I am aware of the odious names with which we are branded...we are accused of rash and impious innovation, for having ventured to propose any change at all on the former state of the church." And yet, the spirit of reformation isn't a "new is better" strategy, either. So what is the true "spirit of reformation" today?

The spirit of reformation reveals itself in at least three dynamics. First, there is the dynamic of *confession*. By "confession" we mean the spirit that always treats doctrine and theology as something to believe in, instead of merely something to talk about in an abstract way. Whereas there is a place for academic conversation about doctrine, we treat it in the church as something that will translate into pastoral counseling, sermons and yes, innovative strategies for making our beliefs a reality in the world that we live. This first dynamic will see everything we do as important relative to our beliefs. Just as in Calvin's day, reformation will involve such topics as worship, church leadership structures, evangelistic strategies, pastoral care, etc. *Confession* is simultaneously principled and practical. *Confession* is concerned not merely about ideas, but about a sociology of ideas as this involves then the reformational concept of "church."

Second, the spirit of reformation is *constructive*. What is particularly important here is always going back to the Bible to construct our beliefs. Yes, we do this within a history of doing it. We do this humbly and always mindful that we are not the only people doing it—thus recognizing the need for historical interaction and inter-church, even inter-denominational, dialogue. But in the end, we talk about Scripture, we reference Scripture, we build upon the foundation that was laid not by Calvin or Luther or any one modern personality, but by the apostles set apart by Christ (Ephesians 2: 22–23). Sunday expositions are the focus of our theologizing. And we do this mostly to build something, not merely to tear something down. (see "Spirit" on page 3)

Mission to Honduras

BY MELANIE L. MCLEOD

As we all sat in a circle, each person describing his or her reasons for wanting to do foreign missions, there was a growing excitement about the incredible opportunity that lies ahead. This summer, five members of Christ Presbyterian Church will travel to Honduras for two weeks to participate in a church planting effort through Missions to the World (MTW). The five are your pastor, Preston Graham, Joanne Liu, Diane Miller, Matthew Phillips, and myself.

(see "Mission" on the back page)

Please pray for the following aspects of our trip:

Flexibility: That we would go to Guanaja with no expectations and a willingness to be used for God's purposes in any way that he may show us.

Planning: That the rest of our preparations for the trip would go smoothly.

Support: That others would catch a vision for God's purposes in Guanaja.

Humility: That we would learn to submit to one another in love.

Safety: That we will have a safe, healthy trip.

CONTENTS



The Spirit of Reformation Today!

Rev. Preston Graham

Mission to Honduras

Melanie L. McLeod



Preschool Moms

Jennifer Cheng



Tape Ministry Update

Rebekah Prokop

1

1

2

3

Preschool Moms

BY JENNIFER CHENG



Perspectives

The women's fellowship group that meets on Tuesday mornings at the study center is also known as the "Preschool Moms." It has proven to be an exciting ministry and a blessing to all that attend. Every week we enjoy a much-anticipated opportunity to fellowship and pray. It is a wonderful time of sharing: our joys, our trials, our uncertainties, our small successes, and above all, our utter reliance on Christ to sustain us each and every day. We also find it a time of encouragement, as we are able to be vulnerable with one another and learn from one another in the challenging task of being godly wives and mothers.

Our time of fellowship begins at 9:45 when mothers start to appear, herding their little flocks (yes, even just two children and accompanying paraphernalia can seem exactly like a flock—of excited geese, perhaps) downstairs to the kids' room. By 10:00 (or more often a quarter after) the moms have collected their cups of coffee or tea and have made their way into the living room, chattering incessantly, as only moms who have been given the chance at a full hour of adult conversation can! What happens next varies from week to week. On some days we truly feel a significant need for prayer, and we spend some time sharing, and unburdening our hearts a little, as well as keeping tabs on areas of need among our families, friends and neighbors. Then we pray together, not only for ourselves, that we might be more Christlike in our roles as children of God and as wives and mothers, but also for our church, its peace and purity, its leadership, and for your prayer requests. We are committed to pray each and every week, so please use those blue cards in the registry!

On alternate weeks, before we pray, we enjoy a time of teaching (and much discussion!), which is led by Anita Hinkson or myself. This past year we have been working through J. C. Ryle's *The Duties of Parents*, an excellent and entirely appropriate nineteenth-century overview of what our goals should be as we train up our children "in the way they should go." We draw on other resources such as *The Mother at Home* by John S. C. Abbott and *Shepherding a Child's Heart* by Tedd Tripp (both available in the bookstore) as well as others. All of us cherish these times, as we look for guidance to those who have been through this season of life and have studied theology as well as biblical child-rearing. They help direct our thinking as we seek to glorify God in how we love and teach our precious children. We also were very privileged to have Jon Hinkson's mother visit our group one week and share her experience and insights into parenting. What a wonderful encouragement to be disciplined and taught by an older woman! In fact, we enjoyed

**It is a wonderful time of sharing:
our trials, our small successes, and
above all, our utter reliance on Christ
to sustain us each and every day.**

it so much that if any of you women in our church who have already passed through this particular stage would be willing, we would like to offer you an opportunity to come talk with us and share your experiences of how God has led you in your parenting walk.

While the mothers are upstairs in the relative calm of the parlor, our children are being led in a "Story Hour" by our enthusiastic pastor, Preston Graham (did you know that he plays the guitar?!) Through "toddler tunes" and play along singing, *Read Aloud Bible Stories* by



Some members of the church eating dinner before the School of Discovery on Wednesdays.

Ella K. Lindvall, and *The Story Hour*, an evangelistic Preschool and Kindergarten curriculum from CRC publications, the children have loads of fun while also learning about God and his work of creation and salvation through Christ. They are given a snack (their favorite part!) and plenty of time to play downstairs in the basement in the kids' room. Now here's another consideration for you, men *and* women: if you are *ever* available on Tuesday at 10:00, why not come and join our children? Preston could use your help as our group grows larger, and everyone, I'm sure, could benefit from an hour of lighthearted voices and small bear hugs. We want our children to have other Christian men and women involved in their lives and teaching them about our Lord, and you could do it!

As is true for every women's fellowship group, our purpose is also to provide an opportunity for both non- and new-believers to be welcomed into the church. We hope that as word of this group spreads, (this was our first year) we will be able to draw others in, and that is yet another area where you can help. If you know of or meet a mother of young children who might be interested in our group, by all means inform her or please let us know, and one of us will certainly invite her and her children. For without Christ, the work of the Spirit, and God's daily grace, being the mother of preschoolers can be an overwhelming responsibility, and there are surely many young mothers in need in our communities.

If you have any questions or ideas for us, or would like to serve in one of the ways mentioned, please do not hesitate to call me at 488-3622 or Anita at 624-4742. We are your family, part of Christ's body, and I am very glad we had this opportunity to share with you what is happening in the women's ministry.



Jennifer Cheng, her husband Shi-Jen, and children Vivian and Timothy are members of CPC.

Beg, Buy and Borrow:

Do Whatever You Can to Be Fed in Christ
(The Tape Ministry Update)

BY REBEKAH PROKOP



Briefing

Wouldn't you like to wake up in the morning to a perfect day? The sun shining through your window, wafting on the scent of lavender...a hot cup of coffee at the kitchen table...the sound of Preston's voice....

Wait. Something doesn't exactly sound ordinary here. Rewind! "...kitchen table...Preston's voice...."

Yes, it's true. You may not get the sunshine or the lavender, but you can renew your mind and spirit while you're getting ready for work (or while you're stuck in traffic) by taking advantage of the resources available through the CPC Tape Ministry.

An effort that originally began by providing sermon tapes for nursery workers, this one-woman show has evolved into a team of five. Not only can tapes provide members with solid Christian teaching during the week, but they're also a great way to reach out to those outside our church community. Eventually, the team hopes to further expand its reach through a weekly ministry to 'shut-ins.'

Right now the team is in the process of introducing bulk pricing rates (cheaper by the dozen!) and finding more attractive covers/aesthetic motifs for our buyers. You may already have noticed some of the theme booklets displayed on the bookstand or on our Tape Ministry display table. These are the precursor to even more theme booklets in the future.

Tapes and booklets are also available in the CPC Study Center library. Our bold leader, Jeff Masse, has taken on the formidable task of restructuring the library system so that it is more user-friendly; in the meantime, however, feel free to browse in the library or ask Jeff for help locating the tape of your choice.

Finally, the Tape Ministry is looking for one more team member to help with our many new projects. The new member will be rewarded with delicious meals, good times with fun people and, most importantly, the satisfaction that comes from serving God's people.

So, do you want to jog with Job? Soak in the tub and gain spiritual insight? Beg, buy, or borrow—however you take advantage of the Tape Ministry's resources, you won't regret it.

Rebekah Prokop and her husband, Chris, are both members of Christ Presbyterian Church and serve on the Tape Ministry team.

Spirit

(continued from page 1)

To read Scripture only to condemn or critique without offering positive solutions and models for ministry that will work is something other than the true spirit of reformation. And of course, this is the really hard part of reformation—solutions are much harder than criticism.

The third dynamic of the spirit of reformation is *progressive*. Yes, I said the "p" word as part of reformational language. Reformation will translate theology into a particular vernacular. Ours is, among other things, a vernacular of the present looking to the future, not the past. We will receive and understand the same apostolic ideas that we share with the seventeenth-century reformers within different forms and circumstances than the people of Calvin's day. How do we translate the same old truths into present conditions? We need always to evaluate the medium to discern the implied message—but we need to do this with discernment about the times in which we live. So for instance, if we share with the reformers a commitment to the church as an essential element of the gospel, we should consider that Calvin's "Geneva model" for church planting might be non-reformational if applied today. But maybe not! Each case and each circumstance must be evaluated on its own terms while thinking *con-fessionally* and *constructively* about modern times.

These three dynamics are what we are all about. They mean that we are always on a journey together. The reformational spirit is fluid, not static. We are always revisiting issues, always willing to change. (In fact, principled change is embraced.) This takes the pressure off in one sense, for we don't judge one another or our church as if everything we do or think is absolute. What is absolute is the authority of Scripture to direct our thinking and strategiz-

ing. And I should warn you, this *spirit of reformation* will often result in forming strange alliances. We will not fit the easy party categories. We will be nuanced in ways that make some people nervous—as if our nuance puts us on a slippery slope to somewhere unorthodox. We will be misunderstood at times as being some "party" that we are not. In fact, like the reformers of old, we will be accused by parties at both ends of the spectrum of being in the opposing camp. And yet the true spirit of reformation seeks not to be a reactionary movement, but a planting and building movement, always recognizing that the conversation matters.

This *spirit of reformation* is what CPC is all about. Our confession consists not in keeping the church as some ship lying idle and rotting at her moorings, but in keeping her employed at what she was built for. Not in fearing the sea, but looking to the God who is as present out at sea as well as in the mooring. This ship is constructed of well-established principles of old, but is not given to method worship—new or old. And this ship—the spirit of reformation—is prayerfully being sent into all the world, as the end of each school year reminds us. And to the degree that we hold to this *spirit of reformation*, those of you who live in this wonderful city of New Haven should be encouraged! As many come and go, you will sometimes feel that your city is being used. Without here mentioning the many advantages this transition brings to our city, we are reminded of the great privilege we have to both receive and send people throughout the world. You wonderful people of CPC are God's instruments for a reformation today. Be encouraged!



Preston Graham is the pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church.

The following audio tape theme booklets can be purchased or checked out of the library. Tapes are \$3.00 each with discount rates for theme booklets.

Small booklets:

Mission of the Church
Leadership of the Church
Work: Applying the Gospel
Framework for Life: Kingdom Preamble (Gen. 1-2)
Depression
Expositions in Ezra
Expositions in Jonah

Large Booklets:

Expositions in Genesis
Expositions in Matthew
Expositions in Proverbs
Expositions in I Peter
Expositions in Jude
Expositions in Ephesians

Also available are this year's church history lectures and tapes from Ligonier Ministries. CPC alumni—don't miss out on this ministry just because you're not in New Haven anymore! Please feel free to e-mail or call members of the Tape Ministry team for details or to order tapes.

Jeff Masse
(203) 483-8281
e-mail: jeffm67@juno.com

Rebekah Prokop
(203) 332-1774
e-mail: cprokop@snet.net

Mission

(continued from page 1)

The trip takes place July 31 through August 14 on the island of Guanaja, where, according to Joanne Liu, the rainy season (to which we'll be leaving three weeks prior) brings mosquitoes and biting sand flies that can eat a man alive in fifteen minutes. Needless to say, your prayers for health and safety are *greatly* appreciated.

Our group's primary objective is to develop a trust with the people on the island through word and example with the eventual goal of a church plant. Our personal goals for the trip, however, are as diverse as the personalities behind them.

Joanne Liu reports, "Church planting efforts which began out of relief missions in the aftermath of Hurricane Mitch have already been tremendously well received by the people of Guanaja. This is a really exciting time as MTW continues in the first stages of building a rapport with community leaders and the rebuilding of lives for Christ. I am excited to see what God will do in teaching us to work and think ecclesiastically among the members of our team as well as members of the larger body of Christ."

Diane Miller wants to serve the people of Guanaja not only in a spiritual sense, but in a

physical capacity as well. She is a physical therapist and plans to assist those in need of rehabilitation. While hoping to practice her Spanish with the people of Guanaja, Diane has discovered that they speak English. (The Bay Islands were once British colonies.)

As the group's youngest member, Matthew Phillips says, "I personally feel I can offer a unique perspective on the problems and difficulties that we may face [as a group]. I am also eager to learn about another culture, believing this may help me in the future dealing with people who are different than I am. I also feel I could gain a stronger faith by taking this trip."

Our denomination is sending workers from many churches to help rebuild the island of Guanaja after the hurricane. What excites me most is that these efforts are linked to an effort to begin a church on the island. It is the ministry of word and deed coming to together for the purpose of church planting that is both strategic and exciting. We are blessed as a church to participate in these efforts by sending five of our own. This is the true meaning of "fellowship" as Paul envisioned it for the connective church of Jesus Christ.

As for me, I simply want to be an instrument in sharing the message of Christ's redemptive

plan with people who have more than likely never heard the true gospel in their lives. I want to see these people develop a desire for a church in which to worship the God who has saved them from an eternity of hopelessness.

MTW sends thousands of people all over the globe to spread the gospel through church plants. The group from CPC will be the last leg of MTW's summer mission project in Honduras. We look forward to seeing God's plans for the island of Guanaja come to fruition.



Melanie is a magnet resource teacher at a New Haven public high school and is a member of CPC.



theWindow

Editors Katie Levesque

Rebekah Prokop

Graphic Designer Mihira Jayasekera

Website Designer Mary Smith



theWindow

135 Whitney Avenue, New Haven, CT 06510

